

“AMI BETS ON OPEN SOURCE FOR EMBEDDED SPACE”



■ SRIDHARAN MANI
DIRECTOR AND CEO, AMERICAN MEGATRENDS INDIA

American Megatrends Inc (AMI) is a leading player in storage, embedded and computing spaces across the globe. It sees open source as the present and future in the embedded space. Sridharan Mani, director and CEO, American Megatrends India, spoke to Vanisha Joseph of EFY about the intense relationship developing between open source and embedded systems, and the sea of opportunities it holds for the developer community

What are the opportunities for FOSS and Linux experts in the IT industry? What segments look promising?

Open source is becoming a hot bed of opportunities for FOSS and Linux experts. The embedded market is a growing segment in the IT industry with Linux dominating the space. This has resulted in most embedded players like us looking for more Linux related resources (professionals).

Further, if you deviate from the desktop and PC world and start looking at the mobile world, you can see a huge role played by open source today. Most mobile devices do not have enough processing power, memory, etc, hence cannot be run on a fat operation system or a flat client. The operating kernel needs to be lean and mean and that is easily achievable using open source.

Linux, for instance, allows you to have the kernel as small as possible, apart from making adaptability very easier. Thus, Android, a software stack for mobile devices that uses a modified version of the Linux kernel, is fast picking up, especially in the smartphone segment. This, in turn, is driving demand for FOSS and Linux experts in the embedded and mobile devices segment.

Does the use of Linux/FOSS platforms or technology tools give one an edge in project development?

We work extensively on embedded and mobile applications. Solution providers like us do not go to the market and ask customers to choose Linux (open source) or Windows (proprietary). Typically, we have noticed that in the market customers prefer Windows for its rich graphical user interface (GUI) for commercial desktop applications, but for mobile or embedded segment GUI takes a back seat. What is more important is how quickly and efficiently can one have

the porting done to the hardware.

Most mobiles have ARM-based hardware on which porting Linux is easier, making the development cycle faster. Further, for some projects involving our defence customers, wherein they make their own architecture, Linux is the only option as Windows doesn't support all architectures.

What is the cost advantage achieved using open source for project development? Is the cost advantage offset by the high maintenance cost that often gets associated with open source?

Open source has cost benefits at two levels—cost of development and runtime cost. Using open source, one can easily open and port on the hardware as the source code is available. This helps to identify problems in a shorter period and provide solutions faster.

In our business, time is money and thus faster development cycle translates into savings in development costs. However, the bigger impact is on runtime cost. If you build an application using Linux, no associated costs are involved when you ship the embedded hardware. But, if the application is built on proprietary software, apart from one-time investment in the software, the upgrade cost needs to be paid on mobile devices too. Thus Linux is a one-time investment for development, with no royalty or runtime licence cost associated with it.

Talking about the maintenance cost, it is more relevant to the desktop and PC world than the mobile space we are into. Typically, in the mobile segment, we see people changing their phones once every two-three years. Further, most people don't go and load new applications to their devices, making the chances of mobiles crashing low. Thus mainte-